INC-2026-0413: PowerShell Download

Sample incident ticket for playbook 02. All names, IPs, hashes, and details are fictional.

Ticket	INC-2026-0413	**Status**	Closed - true positive, host compromised
Host / User	WKS-FIN-014 / m.otaibi	**Severity**	High (code executed, persistence found)
Analyst	Majed (L1)	**Escalated to**	L2 / Incident Response

Summary

EDR alerted on PowerShell downloading and running a file from an unknown site on a finance workstation. Winword.exe started PowerShell with an encoded command, which downloaded an executable and ran it. EDR was in detect mode, so nothing was blocked. The user had not noticed anything. A scheduled task for persistence was found on the host.

Timeline (UTC+3)

Time	Event
14:12	User opened invoice_Q3.docm (email attachment). Winword.exe spawned powershell.exe with -EncodedCommand
14:13	PowerShell downloaded update.exe from 198.51.100.77 to C:\Users\Public\ and ran it
14:14	EDR alert fired (detect mode, not blocked), ticket created
14:18	Analyst reviewed alert, decoded the command (Invoke-WebRequest + Start-Process), confirmed the process tree
14:22	File hash and URL flagged as malicious on threat intelligence and sandbox
14:25	Host isolated through EDR, process killed, escalated to L2/IR
14:35	URL, IP, and hash blocked. Phoned the user: did not know about it, only opened an emailed invoice
14:50	Searched other hosts for the hash and IP: WKS-FIN-019 contacted the IP, no execution found
15:10	Scheduled task created at 14:14 found on WKS-FIN-014 (persistence), removed during IR

Findings

- Parent process was winword.exe, a typical phishing macro pattern
- Command was base64 encoded and used Invoke-WebRequest and Start-Process
- Downloaded file and URL flagged malicious by multiple threat intelligence sources
- File ran, outbound connection to the same IP, scheduled task created for persistence
- A second host contacted the same IP but did not execute the file

Actions taken

- Host isolated through EDR, malicious process killed
- URL, IP, and file hash blocked
- Scheduled task removed, host handed to IR for reimage
- User password reset as a precaution
- Second host checked and monitored

Evidence attached

- EDR alert details and full command line, plus the decoded command
- File hash (SHA256, sample value) and threat intelligence results
- Process tree screenshot: winword.exe > powershell.exe > update.exe
- Call note: time, who, what the user said
- Timeline of my actions

Root cause

User opened a macro-enabled document from a phishing email. EDR was in detect mode, so it did not block the execution.

Recommendations

- Block macros in documents from the internet
- Move EDR to prevent mode for this policy group
- Strengthen email filtering for macro attachments
- Phishing awareness reminder for the finance team

Closure notes

User informed. Hosts monitored for 7 days.